There are various proposals. For example, [Walter] Eytan, [director general] of the Foreign Ministry, raised the idea that we be given a mandate over Gaza. I don't think this is acceptable, and I am sure others will not be prepared to give us a mandate over Gaza. They will not hand over a mandate on Arab territory to the State of Israel. But there is *de facto rule*.

We may have to agree, and I am very willing to agree, to some kind of UN supervision. A UN representative will be based there, or we will have to send a report on Gaza each year. In any case, I regard *annexation* as a great risk. If I had to choose between annexation and the United Nations, I would choose the United Nations. So while there are quite real security dangers, they are hypothetical nonetheless, and can be prevented. But with annexation we would receive 300,000 Arabs who would need to be dealt with right away, and this would immediately change the affairs of the state.

Ben-Gurion continued to lay out his doctrine as follows:

For Israeli rule in Gaza to be well-grounded, the economic connection between Israel and Gaza must be strengthened. One link is already in place—transport via train. At present it is impossible to get from Egypt to Gaza by train, but it is possible to get from Haifa to Gaza by train. In everything that we can we should integrate the economic life of Gaza with the economic life of Israel. After all, there is a desert between Gaza and Egypt—this cannot be changed. You can make a road, you can make a train, but a desert cannot be changed. Gaza is inside Israel—Israel surrounds it on two sides—the east and the north. All efforts should be made to ensure that the integration is as robust as possible, because we have time; first of all, we are only going to reach El-Arish on January 7th. I think that we will need to "take the pulse" to figure out how to delay the withdrawal from there, because in the meantime, from November 2nd until today [December 23] seven weeks have elapsed and we are still far from El-Arish. It will also be some time before we get from El-Arish to Rafah. We have a number of weeks. Over the course of these weeks, we will have to take several economic steps that will integrate Gaza more into our economic life. I heard a suggestion that I think is an important one from Eshkol—laying pipes so that there will be a source of water in Israel for the people of Gaza so that they will be able to cultivate a larger portion of their land, plant orchards, and be dependent on water from Israel. This is another economic project that will link Gaza with Israel, and is by no means an annexation of Gaza by Israel, which would turn Gaza and its refugees into Israeli citizens. . . . If we adopt this position on Gaza, we will need to establish a few projects that will integrate economic life and connect a large number of the permanent residents to Israel's economic life. This is something which Egypt cannot do and which the United Nations cannot do.

Several cabinet ministers at the meeting expressed opinions that were different from those of Ben-Gurion. The meeting ended without a decision, but there appeared to be a clear majority in favor of Ben-Gurion's approach.

On February 11, 1957, the government convened to formulate its position ahead of the UN General Assembly's annual discussion on UNRWA's yearly report. This discussion was set to take place shortly after the Sinai Campaign, in the wake of which Israel became responsible, de facto if not de jure, for the fate of more than 200,000 refugees in the Gaza Strip, as well as about 60,000 local residents (other versions claim much larger numbers of up to 150,000), most of whom had no livelihood.